

CASE ID: 202103710995

EPISODE NAME: China Retaliates Following Xinjiang Sanctions (EU)

2021/03/16 - Ongoing

Sender: China (710)

Target: European Community/Union (995)

Issue: Retaliation (16)

Final Outcome: Ongoing

Summary:

On 2021/03/16, China warned the EU against imposing sanctions on Chinese entities related to human rights abuses in Xinjiang. On 2021/03/22, after the EU imposed the sanctions, China imposed retaliatory travel bans and business activity restrictions on several European individuals, institutions, and think tanks. Although some of the restrictions have been lifted, the episode remains ongoing.

Narrative:

On 2021/03/16, China threatened the European Union in response to the European Parliament's consideration of sanctions against Chinese entities involved in human rights abuses in Xinjiang.¹ China's ambassador to the EU, Zhang Ming, leveled the threat, saying that "sanctions based on lies could be interpreted as a deliberate attack on China's security and development."²

After the EU imposed travel bans and asset freezes on four senior officials in Xinjiang in coordination with the United Kingdom, United States, and Canada on 2021/03/22, China retaliated the same day.³ The Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs announced travel bans and business restrictions on five members of the European parliament, a Dutch legislator, a Belgian legislator, a Lithuanian legislator, and two European scholars.⁴ Four institutions were also targeted: the Political and Security Committee of the Council of the European Union, the Subcommittee on Human Rights of the European Parliament, the Mercator Institute for China Studies in Germany, and the Alliance of Democracies Foundation in Denmark.⁵

The EU escalated the sanctions campaign by voting to freeze its Comprehensive Agreement on Investment (CIA) with China until China lifted its sanctions on EU entities on 2021/05/20.⁶

¹ "China warns EU against 'confrontational' human rights sanctions." *Euronews*, 16 March 2021.

<https://www.euronews.com/2021/03/16/china-warns-eu-against-confrontational-human-rights-sanctions>

² *Ibid.*

³ "European Union slaps sanctions on 4 Chinese officials over Uyghur abuses." *PBS*, 22 March 2021.

<https://www.pbs.org/newshour/world/european-union-slaps-sanctions-on-4-chinese-officials-over-uyghur-abuses>

⁴ "Foreign Ministry Spokesperson Announces Sanctions on Relevant EU Entities and Personnel." Ministry of Foreign Affairs of the People's Republic of China, 22 March 2021.

https://www.mfa.gov.cn/eng/xw/fyrbt/fyrbt/202405/t20240530_11349690.html

⁵ *Ibid.*

⁶ "European Parliament votes to 'freeze' investment deal until China lifts sanctions." *Politico*, 20 May 2021.

<https://www.politico.eu/article/european-parliament-freezes-china-investment-deal-vote/>

The sanctions on members of the European Parliament and on the EU Subcommittee on Human Rights were lifted on 2025/04/30 in an attempt by China to re-start trade discussions.⁷ However, reporting suggested the trade deal was unlikely to be revived.⁸ All other sanctions remain in place as of 2025/12/31.

⁷ Birchard, Roise. "China lifts sanctions on MEPs in EU 'charm offensive'." *DW*, 1 May 2025.
<https://www.dw.com/en/china-lifts-sanctions-on-meps-in-eu-charm-offensive/a-72357774>

⁸ *Ibid.*